

INTERNATIONAL news

Trump proposes 100% tariffs on Taiwanese semiconductors

Donald Trump plans to impose tariffs up to 100% on Taiwanese semiconductors to encourage companies to shift production to the US. Criticising the Biden administration's CHIPS Act, Trump argued



that tariffs would boost domestic manufacturing. Taiwan responded by reassuring citizens of its superior role in the global supply chain and maintaining US relations.

Trump halts Biden's EV charger installation funding programme

The Trump administration has suspended Biden's NEVI funding programme, halting the installation of EV chargers, which affects Tesla's expansion plans. Tesla, a major beneficiary, received \$31 million from the programme. This move could slow EV adoption and impact Tesla, despite Musk's support for eliminating federal EV incentives like the \$7500 tax credit.

Apple struggles in China amid fierce competition from Huawei

Apple's iPhone shipments in China dropped 25% in Q4 2024, facing fierce competition from Huawei, which saw a 24% increase. Factors include China's weak economy, reduced consumer spending, and government subsidies favouring mid-tier local brands. Apple's premium devices are excluded from these subsidies, intensifying competition from Huawei and other domestic players.

DeepSeek's growth challenges ChatGPT's dominance

DeepSeek, an open source AI model, gained massive popularity, surpassing ChatGPT in search interest globally. Its surge, particularly in China, led to overwhelming demand and a spike in its mobile app's popularity. The rise of DeepSeek caused significant stock market drops, significantly impacting Nvidia and raising concerns over AI investment returns.

Singapore to aid US in DeepSeek-Nvidia chip probe

Amid rising AI tensions with China, Singapore pledged cooperation with the US regarding concerns that DeepSeek might bypass Nvidia's export controls by acquiring chips through intermediaries in Singapore. While Nvidia denies violations, authorities investigate whether DeepSeek used Nvidia's H800 chips, designed for China, to avoid US restrictions on AI-related technology.

Japan's new tech export controls strain China trade

Japan has introduced new export controls on advanced technologies like semiconductors and quantum computing equipment, effective by May 2025. These measures, aimed at preventing military use, have raised concerns over potential trade disruptions in China.

Japan is also expanding its entity list, scrutinising Chinese firms, amid US pressures on high-tech exports.

Infineon to open a new semiconductor plant in Thailand next year

Infineon Technologies has begun constructing a semiconductor plant in Samut Prakan, Thailand, set to open in 2026. This facility will focus on back-end production, complementing existing operations in Bangkok. The move aims to diversify manufacturing, optimise costs, and expand the German firm's global footprint, aligning with Thailand's semiconductor ambitions.

Delvitech expands AI inspection into microelectronics and chiplets

Swiss AI-driven optical inspection company Delvitech is expanding into microelectronics and chiplets to address industry complexities. Their AI platform offers customisable inspection, reduced false positives, and real-time defect detection. Supported by a new optical head, the technology aims to drive innovation, improve manufacturing efficiency, and reduce waste and carbon emissions.

Lenovo and Onsemi announce major global acquisitions

Onsemi has acquired Qorvo's silicon carbide subsidiary for \$115 million, enhancing its EliteSiC power products for AI, EV, and industrial markets. Meanwhile, Lenovo has acquired Israeli storage company Infinidat, marking its first investment in Israel. This acquisition strengthens Lenovo's enterprise portfolio and expands its regional market presence.

TotalEnergies and STMicroelectronics sign a 15-year renewable energy deal

TotalEnergies and STMicroelectronics have signed a 15-year agreement to supply 1.5TWh of renewable energy to STMicroelectronics' facilities in France starting January 2025. The energy will come from new wind and solar farms with a combined 75MW capacity. This deal supports STMicroelectronics' goal of carbon neutrality by 2027.

STMicroelectronics considers laying off 3000 workers in Europe

STMicroelectronics is restructuring its business in Europe, potentially cutting up to 3000 jobs, or 6% of its workforce, in France and Italy as part of a cost-cutting initiative. Despite receiving a Euro 2 billion subsidy for a new microchip plant, the company faces challenges due to downturns in the automotive and industrial sectors.

NXP to reduce workforce amid economic and trade pressures

Dutch semiconductor company NXP may cut up to 1800 jobs globally, about 5% of its workforce, due to market pressures and declining demand for automotive chips. The company faces uncertainty amid ongoing EU-US trade discussions and import tariffs.

Honda and Nissan end \$60 billion merger deal amid disagreements

Nissan and Honda have ended their merger talks to create a \$60 billion car giant due to disagreements over power distribution, particularly Honda's demand for Nissan to become a subsidiary. The merger would have helped them compete with Chinese EV manufacturers. Despite the setback, both companies will continue collaborating on technology, with Nissan exploring new partnerships.